SCHOOL ADOPTION BRIEF · MARCH 2026

AI Explorers: Build Your AI Assistant, Piece by Piece

A free, open-source AI literacy curriculum for grades 6–8

Grades 6–8 | 7 Modules · One Semester | $0 Licensing Cost | Chromebook Compatible | Open Source · MIT License

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

What Is AI Explorers?

AI Explorers is a **free, open-source, project-based AI curriculum** for middle school students. Rather than teaching students about artificial intelligence through lectures and readings, students build a working AI assistant across seven modules — adding one capability per module until they have a complete, named, personalized agent they can demo to a real audience.

The program targets **grades 6–8**, runs over **one semester**, and requires **no prior coding experience** from students or teachers. No budget. No vendor. No lock-in.

> 🎯 **Why now?** Districts that build AI literacy in the next 2–3 years will graduate students with a measurable advantage — not just tool familiarity, but the critical thinking and hands-on experience to evaluate, build, and responsibly deploy AI systems. AI Explorers is the most cost-effective path to that outcome available today.

PROGRAM OVERVIEW

Seven Modules. One Arc.

Every module answers one question: "What can your agent do now that it couldn't do before?" Each module closes with students updating their Agent Design Journal — a living record of what they built and why.

MODULE 1

Identity & Deployment

Named, personalized AI agent

MODULE 2

Perception

Agent with image & audio capabilities

MODULE 3

Knowledge & Reasoning

Custom domain-knowledge skill

MODULE 4

Machine Learning

Trained ML model, integrated

MODULE 5

Communication

Agent connected to a live channel

MODULE 6

Ethics & Guardrails

Usage policy + bias audit

MODULE 7

AI Expo

Live public demonstration

Scheduling Options

FORMAT	DURATION	BEST FOR
Full Arc	~18 weeks (one semester)	CS elective, dedicated class period
Sprint Mode	7 weeks (1 week/ module)	After-school, enrichment programs
Modules 1–3 Only	6 weeks	Introductory unit, any subject

COST OF ADOPTION

Total Cost to Your District

$0

Curriculum licensing, software, and hardware costs

ITEM	COST	NOTES
Curriculum license	**$0**	Free forever, MIT license
Software / platform	**$0**	Browser-based; Hugging Face free tier
Hardware	**$0**	Works on existing Chromebooks
Teacher preparation	8–12 hours	One-time; covers full 7-module arc
Ongoing maintenance	**$0**	No vendor, no subscription, no renewals

✅ **Zero direct cost.** The only investment is teacher preparation time — estimated at 8–12 hours for the full arc. All materials are self-contained and ready to use.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

Aligned to Leading AI & CS Frameworks

STANDARD	COVERAGE	KEY MODULES
AI4K12 — Five Big Ideas in AI	All 5 Big Ideas: Perception, Representation & Reasoning, Learning, Natural Interaction, Societal Impact	M1–M7 (all modules)
CSTA K–12 CS Standards	2-AP-11 (algorithms), 2-DA-08 (data analysis), 3A-IC-24 (ethics & culture), 3A-AP-16 (program design)	M3, M4, M6
ISTE Standards for Students	Empowered Learner (1a), Computational Thinker (5b, 5c), Innovative Designer (4a–4d), Digital Citizen (2b)	M1, M4, M6, M7

Full alignment mapping with lesson-level crosswalks available at educators.html.

DATA PRIVACY & COMPLIANCE

Designed for Student Safety

AI Explorers was built with student data protection as a first principle. The curriculum itself collects **zero student data**.

REQUIREMENT	STATUS	DETAIL
COPPA	✅ Compliant	No personal student data collected by the curriculum
FERPA	✅ Compliant	No student records transmitted to third parties by the curriculum
Student data collection	✅ None	The curriculum itself collects zero student data
Third-party accounts	✅ Optional	Hugging Face (free, optional, teacher-managed); no student PII required
Vendor DPA required	✅ Not required	No vendor for the curriculum itself; self-hosted option available

🔒 **Self-hosted option:** Schools deploying their own OpenClaw instance control all infrastructure entirely. No data leaves your environment.

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

Works With What You Have

REQUIREMENT	STATUS	DETAIL
Device	✅ **Any browser**	Chrome, Firefox, Edge, Safari
Chromebook	✅ **Compatible**	Fully browser-based — no app installs
Special hardware	❌ **Not needed**	No cameras, sensors, or special equipment required
Student accounts	✅ **Optional**	Hugging Face (free, teacher-managed)
Internet	Required (most modules)	Offline fallbacks provided for Modules 1, 3, 6
IT setup time	~1 hour (optional)	Self-hosted deployment; zero for browser-only mode

No software installation. No app store approvals. No district-wide licensing agreements. If a student can open a browser, they can run AI Explorers.

IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

Pilot → Department → School-Wide

PHASE 1 · PILOT

Semester 1 · Weeks 1–18

- 1–2 teachers prepare (8–12 hrs)
- Run one class section, full arc
- Host end-of-semester AI Expo
- Collect feedback

PHASE 2 · DEPARTMENT

Semester 2 · Months 6–9

- Expand to 2–4 teachers
- Peer co-teaching model
- School-wide AI Expo tradition
- Establish pacing calendar

PHASE 3 · SCHOOL-WIDE

Year 2

- Standard elective rotation
- Optional cross-curricular integration
- Student AI Mentor program
- Community expo event

TIMELINE	MILESTONE
Month 1	Teacher prep complete, device check, pilot launch
Month 4–5	First AI Expo
Month 6	Department review, expansion decision

TIMELINE	MILESTONE
Month 9	Full department adoption
Year 2	School-wide integration

RISK MITIGATION

Open Source Means Zero Risk

RISK	MITIGATION
Vendor lock-in	Open source — no vendor exists to lock you in
Curriculum discontinuation	MIT-licensed; district can fork and maintain independently
Budget cuts	$0 cost; completely immune to budget pressure
Connectivity issues	Offline fallbacks for 3 of 7 modules
Teacher turnover	All materials self-contained; new teachers onboard from curriculum alone
AI content concerns	Module 6 (Ethics) includes guardrail design; usage policy is a student deliverable
Technology obsolescence	Browser-based design naturally tracks device refresh cycles

🔓 **Free forever — by design.** Because AI Explorers is MIT-licensed open source, it cannot be discontinued, paywalled, or changed without your district's consent. You can copy it, modify it, and own it permanently.

CONTACT & NEXT STEPS

Ready to Move Forward?

We recommend starting with a single classroom pilot. The Educator Hub has everything a teacher needs to begin — pacing calendars, module guides, teacher prep checklists, and assessment rubrics.

RESOURCE	LINK
📚 **Educator Hub**	educators.html — module guides, teacher prep, pacing calendars
💻 **GitHub Repository**	github.com/clawdawg36-cpu/openclaw-curriculum — full source, lesson plans, all materials
🎓 **Start a pilot**	Use the contact form on the Educator Hub to reach the curriculum team
❓ **Ask a question**	Open a GitHub Discussion — the curriculum team monitors it actively

> 💡 **Suggested first step:** Share this brief with your curriculum director or department head. Point them to the Educator Hub. A 15-minute conversation is all it takes to plan a semester-long pilot.